

## Q I usually dye my hair. Are there certain dyes that I shouldn't use?

**If you want to be extra safe, you can switch to plant-based hair dyes, including henna.**

However, there are only very low levels of harmful chemicals in hair dyes, and dyeing your hair once every three months or so during pregnancy is generally considered safe for your baby. What is more likely to happen is that your skin, which is especially sensitive at this time, will have an adverse reaction to the dye, or that your hair will behave erratically—perhaps the color won't take properly or your hair becomes frizzy or brittle. If you're using a chemical dye, even if you've used it before, do a test patch on one small section of your hair first. You might

also consider highlights rather than a full dye—highlights will limit the amount of contact your skin will have with the chemicals, minimizing the risk of an adverse skin reaction and reducing the quantity of chemicals that enter your bloodstream.

## Q Can I still have a spray tan now that I'm pregnant?

**Although there's no concrete evidence either way, in general it's better to avoid inhaling any chemicals, including those in a spray tan, while you're pregnant.** Instead, use a tanning cream or foam that contains the same tanning agents, but is applied directly to your body, removing the

# 60 million

people in the United States carry the **toxoplasma parasite**, but few show symptoms since the immune system stops the parasite from causing any illness.

likelihood of you breathing in any chemicals. Also, cream and foam tans only penetrate the upper layers of your skin, so there is limited risk to your baby.

## Q I love gardening, but are there any hazards that might affect my growing baby?

There are several hazards in the garden, such as working with chemicals, exposure to toxoplasmosis in the soil and on unwashed fruit and vegetables, heavy lifting, and getting up from a kneeling position.

A little light gardening is an excellent way to get outdoors and enjoy nature when you are pregnant, but there are some potential dangers lurking out there in the yard. You need to protect yourself from exposure to toxins such as fertilizers and pesticides, and follow good work practices to avoid injury. Follow the advice here to be sure you and your baby stay safe.



» **Remember to kneel** and stand up safely; lower yourself and push up using your knees and thighs rather than your back or abdomen.



» **Don't spray your plants with insecticide**—leave that to someone else. If there's only you to do it, wear a mask that covers your mouth and nose.



» **Always wear gardening gloves** and try not to get soil on your hands; cats and other animals may have done their business in your yard.



» **Leave the really heavy work** (such as mowing a large lawn or cutting back trees) for someone else and, whatever you're doing, if you feel dizzy or tired, stop.



» **Lift garden debris** and heavy pots carefully, lowering yourself using your knees, instead of bending from your waist. Ask for help if something is too heavy for you to lift.



» **Always wash your hands** with antibacterial soap as soon as you've finished in the yard—even if you've been wearing gloves the whole time.



» **Wear a hat if it is warm** and make sure to drink lots of water—gardening can be thirsty work. Try to do your gardening during the cooler part of the day.



» **Wash vegetables and fruit** thoroughly before eating them (even if you are picking them from your own garden) as the soil may contain animal feces.